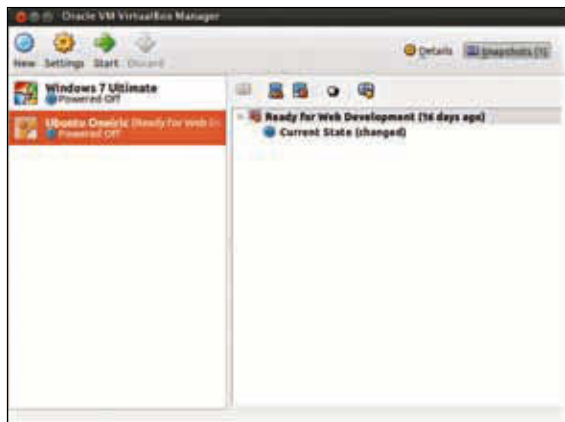


Which one would you prefer? Most certainly the last one: reverting back to the “Started developing” snapshot, because that saves you the most effort! You get the operating system, the installed software and some of your work as well.

To get the most benefits out of snapshots, take a snapshot as soon as you’ve made precious changes to the virtual machine that you don’t want to lose. This way you’ll have many states and you’ll have plenty of freedom to choose the state of the machine you want to go back to. In case you think that you don’t require so many of them, you can delete the extra states you don’t want to go back to (some virtualization software may also call this process “merging”). This will help manage things better so that you don’t get baffled by so many snapshots. In the situation we talked about above, you might just want to remove the “Installed Ubuntu” snapshot because that way you’re saving some space as well as getting the virtual machine in the state it’s most required to be. If you’re using the machine for web development, you would anyway want to have the software installed on it.

Since snapshots would create new files which only contain changes from another snapshot, they don’t take too much disk space either. So you can be sure that if you create a few kilobytes of files in the virtual machines, you’re not losing another 20 GB from your hard disk space; because the whole hard disk file is not recreated.

Snapshots are one really great feature to look for in virtualization software if you plan to use virtual machines which require you to make many changes in the guest operating system while ensuring that you’re able to go



**Figure 3:** A Ubuntu Virtual Machine showing the current snapshots